

Officer's compass

BRITAIN

A compass was vital on a night patrol or raid. Without it, soldiers could lose their way in the no man's land between the trenches, rendered featureless by shelling.

mother-of-pearl face catches the light

Stereoscopic periscope

GERMANY

Soldiers in trenches used periscopes to keep watch on the enemy line. Snipers quickly picked off men who exposed their heads above the parapet.

adjustable eye pieces

Field telephone

GERMANY

Although radios were also used, field telephones were the main communications link in trench warfare. Where telephone cables had been ripped up by shelling, runners carried messages to the front line by hand.

wooden box

handset

screw-on metal filter canister

Gas mask

GERMANY

Effective masks were developed that protected the eyes and face from contact with poison gas and, through a filter respirator, neutralized the gas for breathing.

Folding shovel

ITALY

For an infantryman, a shovel was essential equipment, needed to dig trenches or temporary shelters. This folding shovel was used by Italian alpine troops.

Nail club

BRITAIN

Primitive wooden clubs, with nails or other metal objects at the striking end, were used by soldiers on both sides as a silent, deadly weapon in trench raids.

leather balaclava

leather face mask

Aviator's headgear

BRITAIN

Flying in open-cockpit aircraft, many aviators in World War I wore leather balaclavas and face masks to protect themselves against the cold and wind.

Turkish bayonet and grenade

TURKEY

The Turkish Army in World War I had some obsolete equipment, such as swords and bayonets, but also state-of-the-art German-supplied weaponry such as fragmentation grenades.

steel canister

barrel could fire 1-pound shell

Anti-aircraft gun

BRITAIN

Armies adapted existing guns, firing time-fused explosive shells for air defense. This British "pom-pom" gun, mounted on a pedestal, was used in defense of London against air attack.

pivot changes direction and angle of gun

leather skull cap

Tank helmet

BRITAIN

British tank crews found that when bullets struck their armored vehicle, metal shards flew inside the hull. Helmets protecting the head and face were swiftly adopted to limit injuries.

Desert shoes

BRITAIN

British troops fighting against the Turks in the Palestine campaign sometimes wore wire sand shoes over their army boots to facilitate marching on desert sands.